

Episode 124: Early Summer Special Edition – *The Tatami Galaxy* Notes for Colour Direction Staff

Eh? Rain that seems like early rainy season continues in Tokyo. Still, once it clears, refreshing May winds. My, beer tastes good. ←That again? (laugh)
Now then.

The Tatami Galaxy currently broadcasting on Fuji TV's Thursday late-night "Noitamina" and other slots since April. I'm participating as colour designer, and to great acclaim, this week's broadcast is already Episode 6 (Kanto area). We've reached exactly the halfway point of all 11 episodes.

So this time I'll write a bit about *The Tatami Galaxy*. Title: "*The Tatami Galaxy* Notes for Colour Direction Staff."

Since work overview for *The Tatami Galaxy* has been specially featured and introduced on "WEB Anime Style," I'll omit that here and direct you there (laugh).

I first received this job offer during the thick of *STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM* last autumn. I met Director Yuasa for the first time in November, and at that meeting we had rough discussions about character "colours."

"Simple. I want to keep it simple without using too many colours. Same with backgrounds—like putting one pop of colour in black and white. And basically, no shadows."

That was Director Yuasa's first order. As character concepts, there were coloured illustrations by Nakamura Yusuke, and based on those, Character Designer Ito Nobuyoshi rewrote them for animation. I received those character line art, and ah, they were truly simple!

Actually, I'd never done works with art styles this simple. I'd done a similarly simple character work called *Neighbourhood Story* on TV quite a while back, but while those were simple line art, they had outfit changes every episode and were colourful—a work pursuing "fashion" above all. The complete opposite of this *Tatami Galaxy*.

Anyway, limiting colours, reducing colour separation as much as possible, while picking up the original illustration atmosphere—those became those characters. Particularly protagonist "I" really came together with a "black and white" feeling.

Then Episode 1 began. I also handled colour direction for Episode 1. "Ah, I see!" While working, various things gradually became visible. We tend to increase colour count inevitably. By suppressing that, you can instead create various "colours" across entire scenes—or rather entire screens. Hmm, a bit abstract?

Based on Episode 1 impressions, I convey that "atmosphere" to colour direction staff from Episode 2 onward.

For *The Tatami Galaxy*, once storyboards are complete, each episode's director centres meetings with the overall director, Art Director Uehara Shinichi, and me as colour designer for "art board meetings." Once boards get general OK, art staff and colour direction staff for each episode join "art board meeting" members for "art meetings." This art meeting also serves as colour direction meeting, but after each scene's colour design is complete, I have separate "colour direction meetings" with colour direction staff.

Various "notes" I conveyed to colour direction staff during meetings. First, "simple." Props colours should all lean toward backgrounds. When animation shadows appear by scene, all borders should be wide gradation blend processing. And so on.

And among these, the most important note was "mob character silhouette processing." Oh, "mob characters" means passersby, shop customers—well, "everyone else" characters.

Those who've watched this work probably noticed we boldly use silhouette processing extensively. Like Episode 1's tennis scene, things "simplified" from animation stage are naturally designed with such screen intent, but other so-called "properly thoroughly animated" mob characters—we're doing quite bold things with "colour." In most cases we do "single colour flat painting" and such. Truly "simple." And this becomes quite important visual processing.

This work centres on "I," and we're basically watching that "I's" muttering from relatively close to "I"—that's the basic stance I consider. This "I" isn't very interested in things (people) not directly related to him currently. So we make them "silhouettes." By doing so, acting related to "I" becomes clear with "colours." Well, thinking such things, I ended up with that kind of "silhouette processing."

Colour direction staff were apparently quite bewildered initially. We colour direction staff have habits like "wanting to separate colours for things animated to be properly colour-separated." With fairly realistic works common recently, having such animation before you naturally makes you want to add detailed colours. Then I'd say "one colour is fine," and colour direction staff naturally react "Eh? But... is that okay? Really just one colour?" (laugh).

But when we actually tried single-colour painting on animation cuts and showed them placed on backgrounds, everyone understood with "Ah, I see!" Incidentally, "what colour to use for single-colour painting" involves roughly explaining the target screen, then leaving it to colour direction staff.

As always, my scene-by-scene colour design is strictly framework, strictly blueprints. Colour direction staff face actual cuts and handle actual key animation and director instructions. Moreover, this work has many cuts with non-designed key animation matching and special animation cuts coming up quite different from designs, plus various individual director instructions. I provide direction like "please unify in this

feeling," and consider various things together with colour direction staff, but how to cook that up depends on colour direction staff's sense.

So please enjoy *The Tatami Galaxy* with that "colour" aspect as one highlight too.

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